

Tobias Treppmann

Design leader who still designs — a team, a design system across surfaces, and hands on the work every week

CONTACT

LOCATION

Berlin, Germany

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EDUCATION

M.A. Leadership

Kairos University, South Dakota, USA

2022 – 2026

Theological Studies

Theologisches Seminar Rheinland

2003 – 2007

LANGUAGES

German · native

English · C2, fluent

ONGOING

Independent Consultant

Oratio&Co

2016 – Present · Remote

Collaborative leadership coaching and product-strategy consulting for mission-driven organisations.

PROFILE

I lead design functions and I stay in the craft. Fifteen years in B2B software, most of it vertical products for people who did not choose to be software users: analysts inside banks, parish offices, funeral directors. I have run a team of five, held product management and all of product design at the same time, and built a design system that ships as an API rather than a Figma file. The last year went into AI that runs in production rather than AI that demos.

EXPERIENCE

Head of Product Design

2025 – Present

Bibel TV (broadcaster in linear-to-streaming transformation — iOS, Android, web, connected TV; engineering is an external agency) · Hamburg + Berlin, Germany

- Prototypes in real code, and the agency ships from them — web first, then Android, running against real APIs rather than clickable mockups. Around 70% of the AI-generated code lands. Iteration went from days to hours. The handoff crosses a company boundary and still holds.
- I write the specs and run the board — the tickets engineering works from are mine to write and prioritise, and I check the built feature in production and beta rather than calling it done at handoff.
- AI support copilot, live in production — assistive drafting for viewer letters, emails and social messages, following the handbook's wording, formatting and standard phrases. Restricted topics are named in an explicit restricted-topic list in the system prompt. The draft is suppressed entirely when the input is not a viewer enquiry, and every send decision stays human. Rolled out fully optional.
- AI fundraising ecosystem, built solo end to end — analysis, prompt architecture, prototype, then a production Claude skill generating follow-up content across in-app, web and video.
- Design system as an API — DTCG tokens, Style Dictionary, multi-platform sync. Built without a platform team, so that consistency holds structurally instead of by asking people.

Head of Platform and Design

2024 – 2025

ChurchDesk (vertical ERP for churches and dioceses — ~50 people, DE / DK / UK / SE / NO / CH) · Copenhagen, Denmark · Remote from Berlin

- Designer and product manager at once — product management for the main platform plus all product design. I wrote the specs, ran the ticket board engineering worked from, and was the main customer-facing contact for the launch parish throughout.
- Booking module — the decision I defended through the build — inherited a €20k client-funded booking project scoped internally as a standalone add-on module and reframed it into a platform capability, choosing deep platform integration over the faster standalone module and holding that line to delivery. 70% coordination-time reduction and 90% acceptance at the launch customer, where funerals had to be bookable across 20+ cemeteries. It then shipped to every customer as a general booking capability — room rentals, baptisms, weddings.
- Two designers, no design organisation above us — 1 direct report, and the bar was mine to set and defend.
- AI alt-text in production — shipped for EU accessibility compliance under GDPR plus Protestant and Catholic church data-protection law, across six countries.
- Engineering owned the implementation — the web client in React and the mobile app in React Native were written by the engineers on the team, not by me. Design in Figma, build in code, daily contact across the two-month build.

Head of Product Design

2023 – 2024

Ninox Software GmbH (no-code business platform — DACH / UK / US) · Berlin, Germany

- Prompt-to-database onboarding, with the CEO and technical co-founder (freelance, summer 2025) — the AI-generated schema renders into the real data-model editor, not a chat preview, so people can see and correct what the model produced. It became the basis for the public AI beta.
- Research at a scale a team cannot read — Claude over thousands of forum posts for sentiment, pain points and feature requests, with Dovetail as the shared insight repository. Above a few hundred data points that analysis happens or it does not happen at all; below it, I read the responses, because nuance is the first thing a summariser drops.
- Senior Leadership Team, 5 direct reports including a design lead — and shared design-system governance established across 4 designers and engineering.

Product & UX Strategist

2021 – 2022

Hypoport hub SE (shared services arm of listed Hypoport SE) · Berlin / Lübeck, Germany · Remote

- Service-to-product transformation — partnered with the executive team to productise the service organisation. Case-by-case support became a standard catalogue.
- Methodology transfer — ran design-thinking training for executive leadership and service teams.

Director of Design

2016 – 2021

Datameer GmbH (collaborative data analytics for top US / CA / UK banks and insurers) · Berlin, Germany · team across Germany and NYC

- Five years of data-dense B2B desktop interfaces — big-data pivot tables, column charts, aggregated JSON views, result cards and filter logic. The hardest of them was the query-builder preview, where the result you see is a sample and the interface has to be honest about that without becoming unreadable.
- Research inside institutions that make users hard to reach — pioneered iterative usertesting.com screening to get to analysts working inside banks and insurers. The platform operated under HIPAA compliance among other frameworks.
- Led the design team across Germany and NYC for five years — two UX designers reporting to me inside a four-person design org, reporting to the VP Design. A six-hour gap, held together by cross-timezone collaboration processes I established.
- Design system, co-built — UX defined component behaviour and specs. UI executed the visual system.

EARLIER CAREER PROGRESSION

UX Strategy Lead · *Spreadshirt* · 2014 – 2016 · Leipzig, Germany
UX Manager · *HairDirect* · 2013 – 2014 · Lancaster, PA, USA
User Experience Designer · *andCulture* · 2012 – 2013 · Harrisburg, PA, USA
Web Designer & Front-End Developer · *HOPE International* · 2009 – 2012 · Lancaster, PA, USA
Web Designer · *Bajaa.com* · 2008 – 2009 · Düsseldorf, Germany
Freelance Web Designer · 2003 – 2008 · Düsseldorf, Germany
Web Designer · *Bajaa.com* · 2000 – 2003 · Düsseldorf, Germany
E-Commerce Assistant · *Westfalia Werkzeugcompany* · 1999 · Hagen, Germany

SKILLS

Design Leadership

Team of five including a design lead at Ninox, on the Senior Leadership Team · Hired two, promoted two, and made the call when someone was not the right fit · Interim Head of Product for four months · Coached a design lead through a strained engineering relationship rather than around it · Design-thinking training for executive leadership and service teams at Hypoport

Product Ownership, Not Only Aesthetics

Held product management for the main platform alongside all product design at ChurchDesk · Wrote the specs and ran the ticket board engineering worked from · Interim Head of Product at Ninox · Owned the build-versus-buy and standalone-versus-embedded decisions and held the second one through delivery · 70% coordination-time reduction and 90% booking acceptance at the launch customer

Design Systems Across Surfaces

Design system as an API at Bibel TV: DTCG tokens in three tiers from global primitives through semantic to component, built with Style Dictionary, synced live to Figma and Android with iOS and web ready · One commit propagates to every platform · Co-built the Datameer system, where UX defined component behaviour and specs and UI executed the visual system · Governance run as a cross-functional working group with assigned members and an escalation path

Brand as a System

Built Bibel TV's colour engine: a custom colour-extraction API and config tool, live in production, deriving image-based card gradients perceptually from content artwork with k-means and OKLCH, holding WCAG contrast in both light and dark · The machinery that makes a visual language hold across content nobody has seen yet · Selah — Mindful Transitions: a macOS app designed, built and shipped solo on the Mac App Store, including the product, the interface, the icon and the store listing

Hands-On Craft

Prototypes built in real code against real production APIs, web first then Android · Engineering consumes that code directly and around 70% of it reaches production with minor modification · Iteration moved from days of spec-and-handoff to hours in working code · Engineering at Bibel TV is an external agency, so that handoff crosses a company boundary and holds anyway

AI-First Practice

Claude Code, Claude Projects and Claude skills as daily tools, plus Cursor and Zed · A support copilot live in production for viewer services · An AI fundraising ecosystem built solo end to end, from analysis through prompt architecture and prototype to a production skill · AI alt-text generation shipped for EU accessibility compliance · “Designing with and for AI” workshop series run since 2024 with a partner agency

Customers Who Are Not Software People

Funeral directors, parish assistants and priests at ChurchDesk, three stakeholder groups with opposing needs on one surface · Recurring validation calls with the launch customer's project lead throughout delivery · Analysts inside top US, Canadian and UK banks and insurers at Datameer · Research access into regulated enterprises that had never granted it